IT WAS 10:19 A.M. HAVANA TIME, 11:19 A.M. IN WASHINGTON, and 8:19 p.m. in Moscow. In the commotion that followed the order, one missile was shot after another instead of in an automatic burst. But that no longer mattered. The target was destroyed. Gerchenov commended Riapenko for acting calmly under enormous stress. When Riapenko emerged from the launch cabin, he was welcomed with much more exuberant expressions of appreciation. “They picked me up and began tossing me into the air—that was easy, as I weighed only 56 kilograms,” recalled Riapenko. The man who had almost started a nuclear war was twenty-two years old and weighed 123 pounds. Jubilation was short-lived. Riapenko recalled that they considered what had just happened to be the beginning of a military conflict and expected retaliation.[18]

Major Serovoi reported the downing of Target 33 to General Grechko’s headquarters. Once again Grechko was silent, neither congratulating Serovoi on the news nor reprimanding him for violating Pliev’s order. A few hours later a group of Soviet officers visited the area where the U-2 had crashed. They apparently found Major Anderson’s documents and personal belongings in the cockpit. It is not clear whether they saw his body. The regimental cipher clerk, Gennadii Tolshin, later recalled the text of the telegram that he sent to General Pliev on behalf of Colonel Voronkov: “To Pavlov. On October 27, 1962, at 10 hours 21 minutes, TARGET no. 33, a violating U-2 reconnaissance aircraft of the United States Air Force, was destroyed. It was piloted by Captain R. Anderson, United States Air Force, born in New York City, leaving his wife and three daughters. Voronkov.”[19]

Radio Havana was the first to break the news about the downing of the American plane. Not only was it a major boost to Cuban morale, but also, whether Castro realized it or not, the destruction of Target 33 marked the success of his strategy. His panic over the coming attack affected Pliev, who eventually lost control of his troops, physically and psychologically exhausted by the prolonged suspense. When news of the downing of the plane finally reached Pliev, he was as ambiguous about it as Grechko had been. “The commander in chief did not criticize us,” recalled Garbuz. At least for the present, he did not try to blame the violation of his and Moscow’s order on his deputies. Whether intentionally or not, he had lost control over his subordinates. Like Riapenko and his fellow officers, Pliev